

L2-5 Grey Zones Between Institutional Abstraction and Operational Reality

Chapter 2 Grey Zone Stabilization: How Systems Absorb Without Resolving

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1. Trigger Condition of Non-Reopening

In the previous chapter, grey zones were no longer understood as deviations or exceptions, but as structural outcomes formed through interpretation between institutional abstraction and specific conditions, and continuously carried within the system. The question therefore shifted: it is no longer how these spaces emerge, but how these unresolved conditions are retained without being reopened, while institutional boundaries remain effective.

Under this premise, certain conditions, although recognized as incomplete, do not re-enter institutional judgment, nor are they explicitly accepted or rejected. They are not decisively closed at any specific moment; rather, under the continued operation of institutional boundaries, they gradually lose the possibility of being re-triggered as objects of judgment, and are instead carried forward into subsequent operations. Grey zones, therefore, are not excluded from the institution, but persist within it as unclosed conditions.

Such states are typically not identified as structural nodes requiring redefinition. The institution has not failed; its abstract boundaries remain intact. However, these boundaries no longer require every unresolved condition to be re-evaluated. As a result, grey zones neither constitute explicit deviations nor trigger corrective mechanisms, but are retained within the existing institutional framework. The issue is not resolved, but its status as a condition requiring judgment is structurally weakened, no longer corresponding to a clear judgment pathway.

From a structural perspective, this persistence is not incidental. Whether a condition can be reintroduced into judgment does not depend on its degree of incompleteness, but on whether the institution still retains a pathway for reopening judgment. Once judgment exits its original temporal window, this pathway does not remain intact; it contracts, or disappears altogether. At that point, the grey zone continues to exist within institutional boundaries, but its linkage to judgment has been structurally weakened, and can no longer be reactivated through its original mechanism.

Following this transition, the institution does not pause due to the presence of grey zones, but continues to operate. In doing so, an alternative structural pathway gradually emerges, allowing conditions that would otherwise require judgment to be carried forward without being reopened. Grey zones are neither closed nor redefined, but retained within institutional boundaries as unresolved states. What changes is neither the formal definition of the institution nor the existence of the grey zone itself, but the relationship between them: judgment ceases to function as the primary link between institutional abstraction and specific conditions, and gradually exits its original position.



2. Structural Carrying within Institutional Boundaries

Once grey zones have formed between institutional abstraction and real-world conditions, the issue is no longer their existence, but how they are retained within institutional boundaries. The institution has not been invalidated by these unresolved conditions; its abstract boundaries remain effective, and its formal rules are still in place. However, these boundaries are no longer capable of generating a judgment pathway that fully closes the condition. As a result, grey zones are neither excluded as external deviations nor redefined as complete objects, but are retained within an internal space where the institution remains valid, yet no longer reopens judgment.

Under these conditions, the institution does not eliminate grey zones by refining itself further. Instead, it allows a set of structural carrying mechanisms to emerge within its boundaries, enabling these unresolved conditions to continue into operation. These mechanisms do not alter the formal definition of the institution, nor do they grant grey zones explicit legitimacy. Rather, they allow conditions that cannot be fully resolved to remain within the system without returning to the starting point of institutional judgment. Grey zones are therefore not resolved, but accommodated; not formally recognized, but structurally retained.

This retention does not rely on a single form. Some grey zones are absorbed through spatial containment, where unresolved conditions are confined within localized boundaries and no longer trigger system-wide judgment. Others are deferred temporally, shifted into later phases and carried forward as if already addressed. Some are absorbed through capacity, redundancy, or safety margins, where uncertainty is buffered rather than defined. Others are displaced relationally, repositioned within parts of the institutional structure where judgment is less likely to be triggered. Across these forms, redundancy is not treated as an independent logic, but as one among several modes of structural carrying, providing buffering capacity rather than defining system robustness.

The key point is that these arrangements do not reopen institutional judgment. They do not require conditions to be redefined, nor do they aim at closure. Instead, they transform unresolved states into conditions that can be continuously carried within existing boundaries. The institution thus acquires the capacity to continue operating without reopening judgment, while grey zones persist within it as structurally retained states.



3. Stabilization and Structural Normality of Grey Zones

As grey zones are continuously carried within institutional boundaries through structural mechanisms, their status does not remain at the level of unresolved conditions. With repeated occurrences across different contexts, the institution does not reopen judgment, but allows these unclosed states to re-enter operation in similar forms. Through this repetition, grey zones gradually detach from their original context and begin to exist as reusable structural states within institutional boundaries.

These conditions often appear familiar.

Quick Structural Patterns of Grey Zones

- **Spatial containment:** Unresolved conditions are confined within localized boundaries and no longer trigger system-wide judgment
- **Temporal deferral:** Conditions are deferred to later stages and continue as if already addressed
- **Capacity absorption (redundancy):** Uncertainty is absorbed through additional margin rather than defined
- **Relational displacement:** Conditions are relocated to positions where judgment is less likely to be triggered

These patterns do not resolve grey zones, nor do they redefine their boundaries. Their common function is to allow unresolved states to persist without re-triggering institutional judgment.

As these structural forms are repeatedly applied, their role begins to change. Initially, they function as localized absorptions of unresolved conditions, but over time, they gain stability and are reused across similar situations. When the same types of grey zones are consistently handled through similar mechanisms, their presence is no longer treated as an exception requiring judgment, but as a condition that can be anticipated. What changes is not the formal definition of the institution, but the way it responds to grey zones: judgment is no longer the primary pathway, and is gradually replaced by structural carrying.



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As this substitution stabilizes further, the status of grey zones shifts. They no longer primarily represent incompleteness, but become conditions that can be systematically accommodated. Institutional boundaries remain in place, but they now encompass not only clearly defined conditions and judgment pathways, but also unresolved states that are continuously carried within them. In this sense, grey zones are no longer merely outcomes of institutional abstraction, but begin to shape how the institution actually operates, allowing its operational logic to evolve without formally altering its structure. At this point, the question is no longer how grey zones are carried, but what happens when such carrying itself becomes the norm. As unresolved states accumulate within institutional boundaries and acquire stable positions, the institution may begin to diverge from its original judgment logic, not through explicit redefinition, but through gradual internal displacement. This shift forms the basis of the next chapter:

L2-5 Chapter 3. System Drift: When Stability Becomes Deviation.

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